the shortage of spare parts. I was able to work out an official visit of our air chief but it had to be cancelled at the last minute due to tension with Pakistan along our western border in the early part of 1990. I had convinced the Algerians to ask for an Indian Air Force training team to train them in handling IL 76 aircraft, which they were planning to acquire. Their navy wanted to acquire submarine batteries from India so they were asked to get in touch with the ministry of defence. Their armed forces did subscribe for some courses of instruction, but then language was a hurdle as very few amongst them spoke or understood English.

During this tenure I was fortunate to have had the opportunity to attend three defence expositions: the Defendory in Greece, the Paris airshow and the Euro-Satory, also in Paris. It was almost unbelievable to see a Mig 29 flying barely 200 feet above us and crash in front of our eyes. The pilot was doing a cobra manoeuvre and when he pulled up there was a system failure. Luckily there were no casualties. The pilot ejected and was lucky to survive. I believe the Russians sold a lot of their ejection systems. The other thing I could not get over was a modern helicopter making a full circle. During this manoeuvre, at one stage the fuselage was on top of the rotor blades and the chopper was flying upside down!

This diplomatic assignment gave us an excellent opportunity to travel across the Maghreb, Europe and the UK. We invested in a complete set of camping equipment – tents, sleeping bags, mattresses, etc. Our most memorable outing in Algeria was a week-long camping tour in the wilderness of the great Sahara desert. We drove all over Europe, and enjoyed a vacation every summer, camping wherever we found a nice camping site. Interestingly, we slept out in the open one night in Switzerland, nicely snuggled in our sleeping bags besides our Peugeot 405, in a parking space on the side of the road! The thought that such an action was against the rules never occurred to me. Besides, we were dog-tired after travelling for the whole day, and all camping grounds had closed for the day. We woke up early in the morning and drove on.

We were able to visit many countries in this gypsy mode, as it was a very inexpensive way to travel. We travelled to Morocco, Spain,